

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

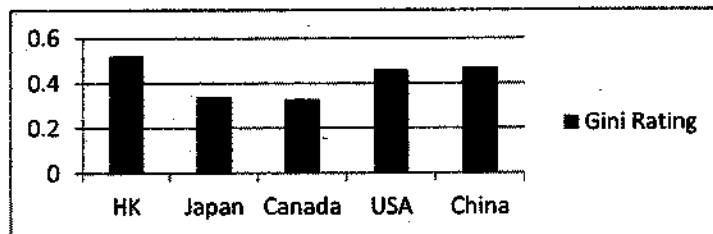
This article appeared in a local newspaper:

Inequality in Hong Kong

The household income distribution report released on Friday shows that Hong Kong's wealth gap has widened and Hong Kong now has one of the greatest wealth gaps in the world. Although the city's overall wealth has increased dramatically, working families and individuals have not benefited from it.

The difference in wealth between rich and poor can be measured by the Gini co-efficient, where zero represents a society with perfect equality. In this measure, the higher the Gini co-efficient, the greater the wealth gap. Table 1 shows that Hong Kong has a Gini score of 0.54, which represents extreme inequality.

Table 1 Gini co-efficient for five countries and regions



Announcing the report, Leslie Tang Wai-kong highlighted the fact that the richest 10 per cent of households in Hong Kong have a monthly income of HK\$112,450 – 44 times more than the poorest 10 per cent, who make an average of HK\$2,560. In particular, the report shows that Hong Kong is unusual because of the high number of very poor elderly people.

Developed countries such as Japan (0.34) and Canada (0.33) are far more equal. The report details possible reasons for this including policies such as a high minimum wage, poverty reduction targets, pensions, controlling rent and higher tax on wealthy citizens.

Your teacher has asked you to discuss inequality in Hong Kong. He has asked your group to suggest ways to help reduce the inequality in Hong Kong. You may want to talk about:

- whether Hong Kong really is an unequal society
- why unequal societies may have problems
- policies that would make Hong Kong a more equal society
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you like living in Hong Kong?
2. Do poor people need more help in Hong Kong?
3. Do people worry about Hong Kong being unequal?
4. Does everyone in Hong Kong have an equal chance to be successful?
5. Is Hong Kong a fair society?
6. Do you think wealth inequality is an important issue?
7. Would you like to live in a perfectly equal society?
8. Are unequal societies unfair societies?